

More Intentional Me

Taking the VIA character strength survey and the MBTI on the same day made me think less about labels and more about practice. In Seligman's talk he explains that psychology should not only focus on what is wrong with people but also focus on building what is strong and that idea made my results feel like something I can actually use. I learned that my strengths feel most real when they turn into repeated choices and my ESFP type works best when I manage my environment instead of relying on motivation. Right now I can use both to study smarter and show up better in group work and later I want to use them to build meaningful relationships and lead well.

My top VIA strengths were humor, love, zest, bravery and social intelligence. These strengths do not just describe my personality. They also show me practical ways I can grow now and later. Humor helps people manage stress and feel more connected so I can use it now to keep group work calm and positive and later to create a supportive environment in leadership roles. Love reflects care, loyalty and close connection which helps me now by making me dependable in friendships and team settings and can help me later build strong personal and professional relationships. Zeest is the energy to approach life with enthusiasm so I can use it now to stay engaged in class and avoid procrastination and later to bring motivation into work that matters to me. Bravery means taking action even when something feels uncomfortable, which I can use now by asking more questions and starting difficult work earlier and later by stepping into bigger responsibilities with confidence. Social intelligence helps me understand other people's feelings and respond to them wisely and that matters now in group projects and later in leadership because it helps me communicate well, notice tension early and make people feel included.

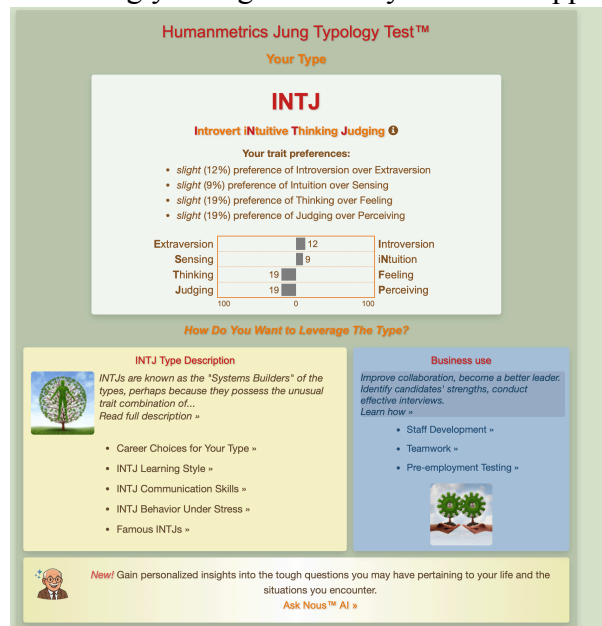
Seligman gives examples of positive interventions that people can practice on purpose and that made the whole idea feel more real to me because it shows growth can come from small actions that add up. To follow that idea I want to track one strength each week and write a short daily note about how I used it. If it is bravery for that week I might ask a question in class or start a hard assignment earlier and if it is zest it might be bringing energy to a study session instead of procrastinating. I also want to connect this to what Seligman calls the meaningful life. I'm not only using strengths to perform better, but also using them in a way that improves the people around me, like being a person who helps a team stay respectful and focused when stress is high in that team.

Seligman mentions "Psychology should be just as concerned with human strength as it is with weakness," and that matches how I felt after seeing my VIA results. It also helped me stop treating my results like a report and start treating them like a plan. He also says meaningful life is using strengths in the service of something larger than you are and that is the direction beyond just being productive in my life. Right now that looks like using social intelligence to include quieter teammates and using love to be consistent even when I am tired. I could also use humor to keep things light while still taking the work seriously. I also like how he separates pleasure from engagement and meaning because it reminds me that feeling good in the moment is not the same thing as building a life that feels satisfying.

My MBTI result was ESFP which stands for extraverted, sensing, feeling and perceiving. For me ESFP explains why I do my best when I feel engaged and connected but I can lose focus if everything stays loud and busy. Susan Cain says “the key then to maximizing our talents is for us all to put ourselves in the zone of stimulations that is right for us” which makes my type feel usable. Even though I lean extroverted I still need the right level of stimulation to do my best work especially when I have to think deeply or learn something very difficult. Right now I can plan two modes of studying quieter time in a calm space for deep focus and louder time for practicing presentations for example. I also want to be more intentional about not forcing constant group work on myself when I really need quiet to concentrate because Cain explains that people do not always think best in high stimulation environments.

Later in the future I want my strengths and my ESFP style to support a life that feels meaningful, not just impressive. I want humor and social intelligence to help me build friendships and lead groups and I want bravery to help me take on bigger responsibilities without shrinking back. I also want to keep using Cain’s idea by building a life where my environment works with me and not against me so I can stay energized without burning out. If I keep practicing my strengths on purpose and aim more for meaning the way Seligman describes and manages stimulation in a smart way like Cain describes then my strengths become a direction for the kind of person I am becoming.

Extra Credit: I asked my boyfriend to take the MBTI test today and here are his results. Interestingly enough he is very much the opposite of me!



Word count : 898

Sources Used:

Martin Seligman, The new era of positive psychology TED Talk

Susan Cain, Quiet, The power of Introverts TED Talk